

August 13, 2026

Cigna Healthcare
Cigna Appeals Unit
P.O. Box 188011
Chattanooga, TN 37422

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Kristie Effertz (MRN MUSC2318077), Claim MUSC-F1C0-1

Patient	Kristie Effertz (DOB 1945-03-23)
MRN	MUSC2318077
Member ID / Group	CIG607831767 / GRP-43365
Claim number	MUSC-F1C0-1
Date of service	2026-04-17
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$386.39
Denial code	CARC 151 / RARC N362 — Payer deems the information submitted does not support this many/frequency of services.
Appeal deadline	2026-11-13

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health Florence Medical Center submits this formal first-level appeal on behalf of patient Kristie Effertz (MRN: MUSC0726452, Member ID: CIG607831767, Group: GRP-43365) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-F1C0-1 for services rendered on April 17, 2026. Cigna Healthcare denied the claim in full, citing CARC 151 ("Payer deems the information submitted does not support this many/frequency of services") and RARC N362 ("The number of days or units of service exceeds our acceptable maximum"), with the accompanying payer remark stating: "Units billed exceed the plan's allowable frequency for this service." MUSC Health respectfully disputes this determination. A single unit of CPT 99214 was billed for a single date of service, and the denial on frequency grounds is not supported by the facts of this claim.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Ms. Effertz is an 81-year-old established patient with a documented history of chronic sinusitis (onset 2007), hypertension (onset 1963), hyperlipidemia managed with Simvastatin, and prior episodes of viral sinusitis and acute viral pharyngitis. On April 17, 2026, she presented to MUSC Health Florence Medical Center, an on-campus outpatient hospital facility, and was evaluated by Amara J. Boone, NP (NPI 1203948576) for an acute upper respiratory infection (J06.9). Given her age, active chronic sinusitis, hypertension, and ongoing medication management, this encounter appropriately required medical decision-making of moderate complexity, consistent with the level of service billed.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

The denial on frequency grounds is factually unsupported. CPT code 99214 was billed for exactly one unit on one date of service, April 17, 2026. There is no duplication, no repeat billing for the same date, and no pattern of excessive utilization evident in this claim. A frequency or utilization denial under CARC 151 and RARC N362 is applicable when the number of units or occurrences of a service exceeds a plan-defined threshold within a defined period. That standard cannot reasonably apply to a single unit of an evaluation and management service billed once on a single date of service.

Furthermore, the encounter itself was medically appropriate. Ms. Effertz is an 81-year-old patient with active chronic sinusitis and multiple comorbidities, presenting with an acute upper respiratory infection. An established-patient office visit at the moderate-complexity level is consistent with accepted standards of care for a patient of her age and clinical profile. The place of service (22, on-campus outpatient hospital) and the rendering provider's credentials are correctly reflected on the claim. The allowed amount of \$198.50 already reflects Cigna's contracted rate acknowledgment, further confirming that the service itself is a covered benefit under the Cigna Healthcare Choice Plus plan, which remains active through December 31, 2026.

MUSC Health requests that Cigna review the claim data in its entirety. The record will confirm that no prior claim for CPT 99214 was submitted for this patient on this date of service, and that the single unit billed is the only unit that could logically be associated with one outpatient encounter. If Cigna's frequency edit was triggered by a system or data error, we respectfully request that the claim be reprocessed accordingly.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health requests that Cigna Healthcare reverse the denial of Claim MUSC-F1C0-1 and reprocess the claim for payment at the contracted allowed amount of \$198.50. Supporting medical records for the April 17, 2026 encounter are enclosed with this appeal. Should Cigna require additional documentation or a peer-to-peer review, please contact our Revenue Cycle Appeals team promptly so that a response may be coordinated within the appeal deadline of November 13, 2026.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record